

JAPAN'S NATIONAL TREASURES

Matsue Castle

松江城 | SHIMANE, JAPAN

A single wooden tablet gave the keep its National Treasure status back — sixty-three years after it was taken away.
A guide to the black-walled castle that outlasted two auctions and a demotion.

THE FIVE NATIONAL TREASURE CASTLES / VOLUME FIVE

Before you go

Admission fees, opening hours and access arrangements described in this book are subject to change. Always check the official website for the latest information before visiting.

Matsue Castle official site: <https://www.matsue-castle.jp/>

Basic Data

At a glance

Name	Matsue Castle (Matsue-jo) — also known as Chidori-jo, the Plover Castle
Location	1-5 Tonomachi, Matsue, Shimane Prefecture
Type	Architecture — castle and keep
National Treasure	Designated 1935; downgraded to Important Cultural Property in 1950; re-designated a National Treasure in 2015
The keep	Four roofs, five floors over a basement, tower type; about 30m tall measured from the main bailey, or about 22.4m from the top of the stone base
Founded	Completed in 1611, a date confirmed by a wooden dedication tablet found inside the keep
Present form	An original keep, preserved as built
Official site	https://www.matsue-castle.jp/

| How this book is arranged

- ▶ Chapter 1 — History: the only original keep left standing in the San'in region
- ▶ Chapter 2 — Reading the architecture: a keep stripped down for war
- ▶ Chapter 3 — Walking the castle: a route guide
- ▶ Chapter 4 — Visiting: hours, access, seasons and the neighbourhood

Matsue holds the most recent National Treasure designation of the five — not because the castle changed, but because the proof of its age took a century to surface. That story, and the black, unornamented keep it concerns, are what this book is about.

History — the only original keep in the San'in region

| A man who served three unifiers

Matsue Castle was built by **Horio Yoshiharu** and his son Tadauji. Yoshiharu served all three of Japan's great unifiers — Oda Nobunaga, Toyotomi Hideyoshi and Tokugawa Ieyasu — and was ranked among Hideyoshi's three senior elders. When Tadauji distinguished himself at the Battle of Sekigahara, the Horio were granted the 240,000-koku domain of Izumo and Oki, and chose a hill called Kameda-yama on the shore of Lake Shinji as the site for their new castle.

| The date a wooden tablet proved

Construction continued under Yoshiharu after Tadauji's sudden death, and the keep was completed in **1611**. That date is not a matter of tradition: it was confirmed by a **dedication tablet**, discovered inside the keep, recording the exact date of completion. Yoshiharu himself died that same year.

| Attainder, attainder, and finally the Matsudaira

The Horio line ended when the third lord, Tadaharu, died without an heir in 1633, and the domain was confiscated. His successor, Kyogoku Tadataka, died only three years later, also without an approved heir, and the domain was confiscated a second time. In 1638, **Matsudaira Naomasa**, a grandson of Tokugawa Ieyasu, was installed as lord — and the Matsudaira family governed Matsue domain for ten generations, down to the Meiji Restoration.

| First threat: a keep sold for 180 yen

Under the Meiji abolition of castles (1873), Matsue's keep was put up for sale, and a buyer was found at **180 yen** — at a time when a single sack of rice cost roughly 3 yen. The keep stood ready for demolition.

What saved it was two local men, the wealthy farmer **Katsube Honuemon** and the former domain retainer **Takagi Gonpachi**, who pooled their own money, matched the sale price, and bought the keep back for the city.

A pattern across the five castles

Chapter 1 — History
Himeji sold at auction for a token sum; Hikone came within a hair of demolition. Matsue was literally bought back by private citizens. **Most of the five National Treasure castles survive today because local people acted** — not because the government chose to

I National Treasure, downgraded, and reinstated

Matsue's keep was designated a National Treasure in **1935**, under the old National Treasures Preservation Law. When the Law for the Protection of Cultural Properties replaced it in **1950**, the designation was reclassified downward to **Important Cultural Property**.

The turning point came in 2012, when a **dedication tablet** was rediscovered at Matsue Shrine, inscribed with a date corresponding to the fifteenth day of the first month of Keicho 16 (1611). Combined with structural surveys of the keep's timber, the tablet supplied the documentary proof that had been missing, and in **2015** the keep was **re-designated a National Treasure — sixty-three years after losing the title**. Of the five, Matsue carries the most recent designation, and it exists because of exactly this kind of research.

The tablet that settled the matter is not on public display inside the keep, but its story — and the near sale of the castle itself — are two pieces of Matsue's history worth knowing before you climb the stairs.

Reading the architecture — a keep stripped down for war



The keep seen past a foreground of pine. The black board siding runs the full height of the building — a deliberately unornamented exterior, built for a castle that expected to fight.

| Black board siding, and the name “Plover Castle”

Where Himeji and Hikone are finished in white lime plaster, Matsue’s keep is clad in **black board siding**, giving it a heavier, more severe presence. A plover-shaped gable on the roof gave the castle its alternate name, **Chidori-jo**, the Plover Castle. The restrained, almost undecorated exterior carries the tension of a castle built while the age of war was still fresh.

| The only surviving keep with a well inside it

One of Matsue’s most distinctive features is a **well built into the keep itself**. Designed for a siege, similar wells were installed at Nagoya Castle and Hamamatsu Castle as well — but **Matsue’s is the only one that survives today**. It was originally 24 metres deep; roughly half of that has since been filled in. Few details make the keep’s war-footing as plain as this single, still-visible well.

| Gobo-zumi stonework, and a shortage of timber

The stone base beneath the keep uses a technique called **gobo-zumi**, which produces an unusually strong, slow-to-collapse structure. Timber was in short supply when the castle was built, so the builders dispensed with a single central pillar and instead **joined shorter posts**, each spanning two floors, to carry the weight of the keep. Of the **308 pillars** supporting the structure, 96 are these joined through-posts, and 130 more are wrapped in thin cladding boards (*tsutsumi-ita*) to disguise splits and knots in the wood. The keep is, in effect, a record of working around a shortage of good material.



Stone steps rising through *gobo-zumi* stonework toward the main bailey. The technique produces a wall that resists collapse even when built quickly, with limited materials.

| The attached turret, and the open top floor

The entrance to the keep is guarded by an **attached turret** (*tsuke-yagura*), built on a stone base one level lower than the keep itself; its basement includes a firing platform (*ishiuchi-dana*) for striking at attackers from below. The top floor of the keep, by contrast, is an open gallery ringed only by a handrail — no walls at all — giving a **360-degree view** in every direction.

Walking the castle

- ▶ Otemae — the approach
- ▶ The site of Otemon Gate
- ▶ The Ninomon and Ichinomon gates
- ▶ The main bailey
- ▶ The attached turret — the firing platform
- ▶ The keep, basement to fifth floor, including the well
- ▶ The top floor — “Tengu-no-ma,” the room of the goblin

Plan	Time	What you see
Keep only	About 1 hour	Otemae to the main bailey to the keep
Standard	2-3 hours	The keep plus a boat tour of the moat
Unhurried	Half a day	All of the above plus Shiomi Nawate and the samurai residences

Before you set off

The stairs inside the keep are steep throughout — wear shoes you can climb comfortably in. On a clear day, the view from the top floor, “Tengu-no-ma,” reaches all the way to Lake Shinji.

What not to miss

- **The black board-sided keep** — a restrained exterior, with the story of the rediscovered tablet behind it
- **The well inside the keep** — the only one of its kind still surviving
- **The firing platform in the attached turret** — a low vantage built for striking at attackers from below
- **The 360-degree view from “Tengu-no-ma”** — the city of Matsue and Lake Shinji spread out in every direction

| The view from the top



Looking out from “Tengu-no-ma,” the open top floor, over the keep’s own roof tiles toward the city of Matsue and Lake Shinji beyond. With no walls at this level, the view runs unbroken in every direction.

The well two floors below, the open gallery up here — between them, the keep sums up its whole character: built to survive a siege, and finished with a view that has nothing to do with war at all.

Visiting

Admission

Admission	1,200 yen for adults; free for primary and middle school students (revised July 2026)
Open	Hours vary by season
Access inside	Open year-round; the interior of the keep can be visited
Official site	https://www.matsue-castle.jp/

Fees and hours change. Please check the official website before you travel.

Getting there

Nearest station	JR Matsue Station
By bus	The Matsue Lakeline loop bus from bus stand 7 on the station's north side to "Matsue Castle (Otemae)," about 10 minutes (210 yen one way for adults), then about 8 minutes on foot
On foot	About 25 minutes from the station
By car	Paid car parks nearby

The castle through the year

Spring	Cherry blossom on the castle hill set against the black keep
Summer	A boat tour of the moat — cool water views of the castle from below
Autumn	The finest season for a stroll through the castle town, and for the sunset over Lake Shinji
Winter	Clear air extends the view from "Tengu-no-ma" on the top floor

| Nearby

A boat tour of the moat is Matsue's signature way to see the castle from a different angle, and Shiomi Nawate, the old samurai quarter along the northern moat, is the most complete castle-town street left in the city.



A Horikawa moat boat, passing beneath the trees that line the water, with the keep just visible beyond. The low boats pass under bridges that leave barely any headroom to spare.



Shiomi Nawate, its pines and earthen walls lining the moat. Named one of Japan's 100 most beautiful streets, it is the best-preserved samurai quarter in Matsue.

| Local food

- **The Seven Delicacies of Lake Shinji** — sea bass, freshwater shrimp, eel, pond smelt, whitebait, carp and freshwater clam; remembered locally by the mnemonic “su-mo-u-a-shi-ko-shi”
- **Shinji clams** — large, meaty freshwater clams from the brackish lake; Japan's largest catch of this variety comes from here
- **Izumo soba** — buckwheat noodles milled with the husk still on, giving them a dark colour and a pronounced aroma

| Lafcadio Hearn's old residence



The gate to the old residence of Lafcadio Hearn (Koizumi Yakumo), on Shiomisawate. Hearn, the writer best known for *Kwaidan*, his collection of Japanese ghost stories, lived here during his time in Matsue.

The house sits along the same street as the samurai residences, a short walk from the castle. A museum dedicated to Hearn stands nearby, covering his life in Matsue and his writing on Japan for an English-speaking readership more than a century ago.

- **Samurai residences** — middle-ranking samurai houses on Shiomisawate, preserved essentially as they stood roughly 280 years ago (a Matsue City cultural property)
- **Lafcadio Hearn Memorial Museum and old residence** — see above
- **Lake Shinji at sunset** — one of Japan's celebrated sunset spots; a fitting end to a day spent at the castle

Credits and notes

Image credits

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Principal sources

Matsue Castle official site — <https://www.matsue-castle.jp/>

Shimane Tourism Federation (Kankou Shimane)

Sekai Isan no Sekai (feature on Matsue Castle's National Treasure re-designation)

Japan's National Treasures — Matsue Castle

The Five National Treasure Castles, Volume Five

Only five castle keeps in Japan are designated National Treasures:

Himeji, Matsumoto, Inuyama, Hikone and Matsue. This series visits each of them in turn.